UCC 301/COM 422 L5

PLANNING AND CONDUCTING LITERATURE REVIEW

A literature review is a survey of everything that has been written about a particular topic, theory, or research question. The word "literature" means "sources of information". The literature will inform you about the research that has already been conducted on your chosen subject. Literature reviews usually provide a background for larger work, or it may stand on its own. Much more than a simple list of sources, an effective literature review analyzes and synthesizes information about key themes or issues.

Purpose of Literature Review

Literature survey is a collection of research publications, books and other documents related to the defined problem. It is very essential to know whether the defined problem has already been solved, status of the problem, techniques that are useful to investigate the problem and other related details.

A literature review goes beyond the search for information and includes the identification and articulation of relationships between existing literature and your field of research. Literature review enables the researcher to discover what has been already been written about a topic and to understand the relationship between the various contributions. This will enable the researcher to determine the contributions of each sources (books, article, etc.) to the topic. Literature review will also enable the researcher to identify and (if possible) resolve contradictions, and also determine research gaps or unanswered questions.

Even though the nature of the literature review may vary with different types of studies, the basic purposes remain constant and could be summarized as follows:

- Provide a context for the research
- Justify the research
- Ensure that the current research has not been carried out by another person
- Show where the research fits into the existing body of knowledge
- Enable the researcher to learn from previous theory on the subject
- Illustrate how the subject has been studied previously

- Highlight flaws in previous research
- Outline gaps in previous research
- Show that the work is adding to the understanding and knowledge of the field
- Help refine, refocus or even change the topic

Summary of functions of Literature review

Reason for Literature review	Descriptions
Bring clarity and focus to research problem	• Better understand the subject area • To conceptualize research problem clearly and precisely • To understand the relationship between research problem and the body of knowledge in the area • Contextualization shows awareness of the work going on in field and identifies the niche to occupy
Improve your methodology	• If similar procedures and methods others used to the ones that you are proposing, • to learn what procedures and methods have worked well for them, what problems they have faced with them. • To select a methodology that is capable of providing valid answer to your research questions
Broaden your knowledge	• It ensures to read widely around the subject area to conduct the study • As you are expected to be an expert in your area of study, it helps fulfill this expectation. • It also helps to understand how the findings of the study fit into the existing body of knowledge.
Contextualize your findings	• How do your answer research questions compare with what others have found? • What contribution have been able to make in to the existing body of knowledge? • How your findings different from those of others? • To answer these questions go back to literature review • It is important to place findings in the context of what is already known in field of enquiry.

What is involved in writing a literature review?

- Research – to discover what has been written about the topic
- Critical Appraisal – to evaluate the literature, determine the relationship between the sources and ascertain what has been done already and what still needs to be done
- Writing – to explain what you have found

Reviewing Literature

When reading through your sources, you want to remember that you are looking for the "big picture," not a collection of random, separate articles. You are looking for common themes and patterns in the research as a whole. Literature review will also enable the researcher to identify research gaps or areas the topic in question that are still in need of further research? The last section of academic journal articles and conference papers tend to outline areas that require future or further research or. The literature review may also enable the researcher to identify existing contradictions that need clarifications.

The following tasks may be very helpful in accomplishing a very good literature review:

1. Show where you think previous research has left gaps
2. Distinguish various theoretical strains, and specify which theory your work will be in line with, if you are proposing a study.
3. Define terms that will be important for your study, if you will be proposing.
4. If the article is empirical, write down the results of the research study in one or two sentences of your own words. e.g. "people who are between ages 18 – 35 are more likely to own a smart phone than those above or below." Such sentence will inform readers about the important findings from the study being reviewed.
5. If the article is a review, also look for the main point. It may be helpful to read or skim the whole article, look away, and ask yourself what you felt was the main idea.
6. Write down any limitations or gaps you noticed, anything that seems to contradict something you read elsewhere, or just anything that you think is important or interesting.
7. If the article is empirical, it is also a good idea to write down the methods that were used, the research design, the number of participants, and the type of population.

8. Sometimes, you may even want to write down the names of the statistical procedures used to analyze the data or even some of the statistics, depending on your assignment

Writing the literature review

The three parts of the literature review are;

Introduction:

- The literature review must identify the topic by briefly discussing the significance of that topic including a statement that outlines the conclusion to be drawn from the literature review.
- If your literature review is part of a larger work, explain the importance of the review to your research question.
- Defend the importance of the topic by giving a broad overview of the scope of the work you are reviewing.
- Clarify whether you're looking at the entire history of the field, or just a particular period of time.

Body

- Discuss and assess the research according to specific organizational principles (see examples below), rather than addressing each source separately. Most, if not all, paragraphs should discuss more than one source. Avoid addressing your sources alphabetically as this does not assist in developing the themes or key issues central to your review.
- Summarize the works you are reviewing. Just as in any written assignment, use logical organization and clear transitions. Spend more time on the people and works that are considered most important in the field and/or that are most relevant.

Conclusion

Predict where research in the field will go next. If you are proposing your own research study, show how you will contribute to the field. The conclusion would also be a good place to defend the importance of the topic, now that you have demonstrated the current state of thinking in the field.

Locating and evaluating research articles

Locating research articles

There are various sources of research articles and these include: -

1. Journals
2. World wide web
3. Seminars and conferences
4. Unpublished reports.

General evaluation criteria

1. **Authority**

- The authors credentials such as educational background, organizational affiliation and years of experience in the professional
- Authors other published books and articles credibility
- Determine authors association with a reputable organization
- For online resources check domain

2. Date of Publication/Currency/Timeliness

Consider:

- The date of publication
- Frequency of updating
- Revision / edition of the resource

3. Publisher

- In the publishing industry there are thousands of publishers, and it is impossible to know the reputations of all of them.

Examples of publishers includes the following:

- Who is the intended audience for the work for example:
  - **General audience**
  - **Specialized**: written for those with an interest in a specialized area of study i.e. engineers, advocates, accountants e.t.c.
  - **Professional:** written for those with undergraduate and graduate college education
- Language and selection of understandable and appropriate word for the intended readership, it can either be too simple of too difficult.
- If the targeted readers are experts in a specific field of study, general readers may have serious trouble following the discussion

5. Content

- Confirm if it provides background information or it focus more on a specific area
- Does the material cover your topic as you thought
- If is updating what has been established in the field

6. Scope

- Consider the subject of the source

- Relationship to your topic
- The preface/introduction and purpose of your study
- The depth of coverage on your topic

Evaluating Research Articles

Quality and validity

Evaluation of a research article involves an assessment of its quality of validity.

Research question

The research must be clear in informing the reader of its aims. Terms should be clearly defined, even more so if they're new or used in specific non-spread ways. You as a reader should pay particular attention should to errors in logic, especially those regarding causation, relationship or association.

Sample

To provide trustworthy conclusions, a sample needs to be representative and adequate. Representativeness depends on the method of selection as well as the assignment. For example, random assignment has its advantages in front of systematic assignment in establishing group equivalence. The sample can be biased when researchers used volunteers or selective attrition. The adequate sample size can be determined by employing power analysis.

Control of confounding variables

Extraneous variation can influence research findings, therefore methods to control relevant confounding variables should be applied.

Research designs

The research design should be suitable to answer the research question. Readers should distinguish true experimental designs with random assignment from pre-experimental research designs.

Criteria and criteria measures

The criteria measures must demonstrate reliability and validity for both, the independent and dependent variable.

Data analysis

Appropriate statistical tests should be applied for the type of data obtained, and assumptions for their use met. Post hoc tests should be applied when multiple comparisons are performed. Tables and figures should be clearly labelled. Ideally, effect sizes should be included throughout giving a clear indication of the variables' impact.

Discussion and conclusions

Does the study allow generalization? Also, limitations of the study should be mentioned. The discussion and conclusions should be consistent with the study's results. It's a common mistake to emphasizing the results that are in accordance with the researcher's expectations while not focusing on the ones that are not. Do the authors of the article you hold in hand do the same?

Ethics

Last but not least, ere the ethical standards met? Some of the items listed above relate closely to the articles validity since validity is a necessary condition for quality research. In general, validity can be defined as an indication of accuracy, in terms of the extent which a research conclusion corresponds to reality. There are four types of validity that must be considered when designing and evaluating a piece of research. These are:-

a) External validity

This relates to generalizability. That is the application of the results to other settings.

b) Construct validity

When you read and evaluate research articles, you should critically examine the appropriateness of the measurement instruments used in terms of both their validity and reliability. That is validity related to measurement is construct validity

c) Statistical Validity (conclusions)

This relates to the use of appropriate analytical tools and the power or ability to detect a relationship of the statistics used. The question addressed by this type of validity is- Is there a relationship between the variables?

d) Internal validity

This relates to the logic inherent in the research.